the Lieberman character instructed. “Why photograph the air? You should photograph things.”

His appointment capped off a tumultuous period in Israeli politics. A fortnight earlier, in mid-May, commentators had been talking about a unity government. Isaac Herzog seemed ready to bring his center-left Zionist Union, or at least a chunk of it, into the coalition. He told a group of party activists that he had “identified a rare regional diplomatic opportunity” which justified joining Netanyahu’s right-wing cabinet, a move that would see him assume the role of foreign minister. Herzog never actually identified this opportunity, but the talks received an unlikely boost from Abdel Fattah al-Sisi, the Egyptian president. “There is now a great opportunity for a better future and life and greater hope and stability,” he said during a speech in Cairo. “Should not we seize the chance and move in that framework?” It was seemingly an important endorsement: Sisi is probably more popular with Israelis than either Netanyahu or Herzog. (I had a framed Sisi propaganda poster hanging in my apartment, a souvenir from covering the coup in 2013; pizza guys and plumbers would often nod approvingly and tell me that he should lead the Arab world.)

“Netanyahu has a need to expand his coalition,” said Uzi Arad, his former national security adviser, suggesting it could purge the government of what he delicately called “hardline” elements. “It would moderate Israel’s image to the world.”

And then, as suddenly as the negotiations began, they ended. Lieberman announced on 18 May that he had been offered the defense ministry in exchange for bringing his party, with its paltry six Knesset seats, into the coalition. He is one of Israel’s most bombastic politicians—the opposite of Herzog in both style and substance. In 1998 he even proposed bombing the Aswan High Dam (and thus killing millions of people downstream) to punish Egypt for supporting Yasser Arafat.

The prime minister continued to publicly offer Herzog a job, but the Labor leader, realizing he had been played, quickly bowed out. “Netanyahu has now turned himself into the government secretary of the far right-wing of Avigdor Naftali Smotrich,” he wrote on Facebook, referring to three right-wing lawmakers (Lieberman, Naftali Bennett, and Bezalel Smotrich, the settler advocate and “proud homophobe” from the Jewish Home party). It was a brilliant tactical move on Netanyahu’s part, neutralizing Herzog’s ability to act as opposition leader.